

SECTION EIGHT

BUILDING YOUR MAGIC SYSTEM

Magic is often what makes a fantasy world feel like fantasy, but if magic can do everything then magic really means nothing. Constraints, rules, costs and limits on the magic system is what makes the magic system memorable. When your character reaches for their power, we need to know what they're risking, what they're capable of, and what's completely beyond them.

In this section we build your magic system from scratch: where does it come from? Who uses it? How does it work? And most importantly, what can't it do? But we're also building something else here. In what ways does magic create closeness? How does it generate conflict? How does it force your characters into difficult decisions? Because magic in romantasy isn't just about battles and plot problems. It's about connection, and the ways your characters reach each other, hide from each other, and eventually let someone see their power or their vulnerability.

If you get the foundation of your magic correct, your magic will be believable. Skip it, and you'll find yourself writing your way into corners or solving problems too easily.

The Cost Principle

Here's the real story on magic in romantasy – it's never about having more power, it's always about paying a higher price.

Every time your character reaches for their magic, they should be weighing what they gain against what they risk. That's where the drama lives. Not in the spectacular display, but in the decision to use it at all. What does it cost them? What does it reveal? How expensive is it for them to hold back and how expensive is it for them to let go?

Rhysand's deal with Amarantha in ACOTAR is a perfect example. In order to protect his people he had to endure Amarantha's abuse for fifty years. The cost of protecting Feyre Under the Mountain was a tattoo bargain that to others appeared to be a form of possession. Both of these prices weren't in terms of exhaustion or loss of magical strength. They were personal, relational, and devastating. That's the kind of price that makes magic matter.

The same goes for romance – not just plot. The most interesting magical moments between your leads aren't the grand gestures. They're the small, costly ones. A fire mage keeping a candle burning in someone's window each night. A healer who absorbs pain they could avoid. A telekinetic who adjusts someone's collar without touching them. These gestures cost something, whether that's energy, attention, or vulnerability, and it's that cost that gives them value.

If your magic only provides benefits then it's uninteresting. Magic that helps and hurts, that grants power and demands sacrifice, that connects and divides? That's the magic that makes romantasy work.

Design your magical system based off of one question – what does it cost? The answer to that will help you design the rest of the world around it.

♦ **Core: What can magic do in your world? In a few sentences, describe the big picture.**

Don't worry about rules yet – just get the vision down. What does magic look like in your world? Is it flashy and elemental, subtle and psychological, biological and inherited? What's the first image that comes to mind when you think of magic in your story?

YOUR ANSWER

♦ **Core: Who has access to magic? How common is it?**

Is nearly everyone magical, or is it rare and feared? Is it inherited, learned, granted, or stolen? A quick sketch here will anchor everything that follows.

YOUR ANSWER

How to Use This Section

♦ **Core questions** are the essential building blocks every magic system needs. If you're short on time, answer these first. They'll give you a functional magic system you can write with.

Everything else is **Deep Dive**, important for adding nuance and complexity, but you can return to these as your story develops. If a subsection doesn't apply (no bonded creatures, no forbidden magic), skip it entirely!

How to Think About Magic in Romantasy

Magic in romantasy serves three functions simultaneously. Understanding all three will help you build a system that does real work for your story.

FUNCTION	WHAT IT DOES	EXAMPLE
World Engine	Makes the world fantastical, creates the rules everyone lives under	<i>ACOTAR's</i> courts, each with distinct magical territories and powers
Plot Driver	Creates problems, raises stakes, enables and prevents solutions	<i>Fourth Wing's</i> dragon bonds, where power comes with mortal risk
Romance Catalyst	Creates intimacy, obstacles, vulnerability, and private connection	Rhysand using winnowing to send Feyre private notes,

FUNCTION	WHAT IT DOES	EXAMPLE
		turning transportation magic into intimacy

Not every magical ability needs to directly advance the romance. Winnowing in *ACOTAR* is transportation magic. There's nothing inherently romantic about it. But Rhysand uses it to send Feyre notes, appearing and disappearing paper and pen so they can have a private conversation across distance. The intimacy isn't built into the magic. It comes from the choice to use his power that way.

A Note Before You Begin

You don't need to answer every question in this section. Some magic systems are simple: one type of power, one clear cost, a few firm limits. Others are elaborate, with multiple types, complex hierarchies, and layered costs. Both work!

Answer what matters for your story. If a question doesn't apply, skip it. If you're unsure about something, write it down anyway. You may figure it out as you draft.

The most important thing is that your magic feels consistent and has real consequences. Everything else is detail.

Quick Guide to What You Need

Every story needs: What magic can do, who can use it, what it costs, and what it can't do.

If your romance involves a magical bond: Focus on Bonds, Marks & Fated Connection.

If your characters have unequal magical power: Focus on Who Can Use Magic and Power Imbalance.

If magic is dangerous or forbidden: Focus on The Cost, The Limits, and Dangerous & Forbidden Magic.

If you're not sure yet: Start with the Brain Dump and The Source. You can always come back.

Common Mistakes with Magic Systems

Mistake #1: The Bolted-On Bond

You design a perfectly functional magic system, then add a telepathic bond or soul mark specifically for romance. The bond has nothing to do with the rest of your magic. It operates by different rules, has no cost, and exists purely to make two characters feel things about each other. It makes the magic do the romantic work instead of the characters. Readers can tell when a connection is mechanically imposed rather than earned. The bond becomes a shortcut that replaces the actual work of falling in love.

FIX

Find the intimate potential in the magic you've already built. Any magic system can create intimacy. It's not about what the magic is, it's about how your characters choose to use it. If you do include bonds, make them operate within the same rules as everything else, with real costs and limitations.

Mistake #2: Unlimited Power, Zero Stakes

Your protagonist can do anything with magic. Heal any wound, defeat any enemy, solve any problem. The magic has no meaningful cost, or the cost is "feeling a bit tired." If magic solves everything, there's nothing to struggle against. No stakes means no tension, in the plot or the relationship. Why would your character need anyone if their magic handles it all?

FIX

Make the cost real and escalating. Physical exhaustion is the bare minimum, so push further. Shortened lifespan. Lost memories. Moral corruption. Pain absorbed from others. In *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy's gift lets her sense others' emotions and take away their pain, but it means absorbing that pain into herself. The cost should make your character think twice before reaching for their power, and make readers feel the weight of that decision.

Mistake #3: Magic That Only Creates Problems OR Only Creates Connection

Your magic system is purely an obstacle (their powers clash, magic keeps them apart) or purely a connector (the bond draws them together, shared training creates closeness). Never both. The best romantasy magic does both simultaneously. The same ability that creates intimacy should also create danger. The bond that draws them together should also complicate their lives. If magic only pushes in one direction, you're missing half the tension. **Quick check: does your magic system fall into any of these traps?** *It's much easier to fix these now than after you've drafted three chapters around a system that isn't working. Be honest with yourself; catching a problem here saves pain later.* | Mistake | Does This Apply to Your System? | How You'll Address It | |—|—| | *Bolted-On Bond, a romantic mechanic that doesn't follow the same rules as the rest of your magic* | *Example: Yes, I added a soul mark but it has no cost, unlike everything else in my system* | *I'll tie the soul mark to the same energy cost as other magic, and make it visible only when the characters are both depleted* | | Bolted-On Bond | | | Unlimited Power / Zero Stakes | | | One-Directional Magic (only connects OR only divides) | | |

FIX

For every way magic connects your leads, find a way it also divides them. For every obstacle magic creates, find a moment where that same magic enables connection. The dual nature is where the interesting stuff lives.

Types of Magic Systems

Magic doesn't have to mean spellcasting. Here are different approaches to inspire you, and you're welcome to mix, match, or invent your own.

TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	ROMANTIC POTENTIAL	EXAMPLE
Elemental	Control over natural forces (fire, water, earth, air)	Complementary or opposing elements between leads; loss of control reflecting emotional state	<i>Avatar, The Priory of the Orange Tree</i>
Spellcasting	Words, gestures, or rituals produce specific effects	Shared rituals as intimacy; spells gone wrong creating vulnerability	<i>Harry Potter, The Name of the Wind</i>

TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	ROMANTIC POTENTIAL	EXAMPLE
Innate/Inborn	Powers you're born with, often tied to bloodline	Bloodline politics affecting who can love whom; awakening powers tied to emotional growth	<i>X-Men, Graceling, Ninth House</i>
Blood/Sacrifice	Power drawn from blood, pain, or giving something up	Sacrificing for each other; shared pain as connection	<i>Blood and Ash, Daughter of No Worlds</i>
Emotional/Will-Based	Magic fuelled by feelings, desire, or force of will	Falling in love makes magic stronger or more dangerous; emotions as vulnerability	<i>The Rage of Dragons</i>
Bond-Based	Magic tied to a connection with another being	The bond itself becomes the romantic vehicle; forced proximity through magical partnership	<i>Fourth Wing, His Dark Materials</i>
Artifact-Based	Power resides in objects, not people	Shared custody of powerful objects; gifting enchanted items as intimacy	<i>Lord of the Rings</i>
Transformation	Ability to change form	True form as vulnerability; accepting someone's other shape as acceptance of their whole self	<i>ACOTAR</i> (shifting)

TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	ROMANTIC POTENTIAL	EXAMPLE
Necromancy	Power over death, spirits, or life's boundary	Stigma and secrecy; raising stakes around mortality; "I'd bring you back" as ultimate declaration	<i>Gideon the Ninth, Sabriel</i>
Bargain/Contract	Power gained through deals or binding agreements	Bargains that force proximity or create obligation; loopholes as plot devices	<i>ACOTAR</i> (bargains)
Symbiotic/Parasitic	Magic requires or is enhanced by another being	Dependency as vulnerability; needing someone as both power source and person	<i>Venom, The Fifth Season</i>
Music/Art-Based	Creation through song, art, or expression	Creating something together; art as emotional revelation; songs that only mean something to two people	<i>Wintersong</i>
True Names	Power from knowing the true nature of things	Knowing someone's true name as ultimate intimacy and ultimate weapon	<i>Earthsea, The Name of the Wind</i>
Psychic/Mental	Mind-reading, telekinesis, mental influence	Thoughts you can't hide; mental shields as emotional walls; choosing to let someone in	<i>Shatter Me, Carrie</i>

Which type(s) best describe your magic system?

You can combine multiple approaches.

YOUR ANSWER

If your system doesn't fit these categories, describe what makes it different:

Unique magic systems are memorable. What makes yours distinctive from what readers have seen before?

YOUR ANSWER

The Source

Every magic system has an origin, and where the power actually comes from shapes everything: who has access, how it's viewed by society, what it costs to use, and whether it can unite or divide your leads.

♦ **Core: Where does magic come from in your world?**

Options: the gods or divine forces, the natural world (ley lines, elemental forces), an internal source (bloodlines, souls, emotions), external objects, knowledge and study, a bargain or bond, something unknown or mysterious.

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a single source of magic, or multiple types with different origins?

If multiple, how do they interact, or conflict? Multiple sources can create cultural or romantic divides.

YOUR ANSWER

Can the source be depleted, corrupted, or cut off? What happens if it is?

Vulnerable magic sources create stakes. What would your protagonist do if their power began to fail?

YOUR ANSWER

How do people in your world explain where magic comes from?

Is the truth different from what most believe? Gaps between belief and reality create secrets worth keeping or discovering.

YOUR ANSWER

What traces does magic leave on the land, the air, or the people who live near it?

Magic rarely exists without side effects. Ley lines might hum, corrupted zones might kill crops, magical forges might change the colour of the sky. Think about what a traveller would notice when they enter a place where magic is heavily used – or a place where it went wrong.

YOUR ANSWER

Cross-check: Does your magic source connect to your religion (Section 6)? If magic comes from the gods, your religious institutions should reflect that. If magic predates or contradicts the gods, that tension should show up in how believers and magic users relate to each other.

Who Can Use Magic

Not everyone has to be magical, and who can wield magic shapes everything from social structure to your protagonist's place in the world. It also determines the power dynamic between your leads.

How common is magic in your world?

Can nearly everyone use some form? Is it limited to certain bloodlines, species, or chosen ones? Can anyone learn it with training? Is it vanishingly rare?

YOUR ANSWER

♦ Core: What determines whether someone can use magic?

Birth (bloodlines, species, being "chosen"), training and study, a triggering event (trauma, ritual), possession of an object or bond, random chance, a sacrifice or bargain.

YOUR ANSWER

Can magical ability be gained, lost, or taken away?

The permanence of magical ability affects what characters fear and hope for. Could your protagonist gain power they don't have yet, or lose everything they rely on?

YOUR ANSWER

How does access to magic shape families, marriages, and social class?

If magic is inherited, bloodlines become political. If it's learned, whoever controls the training controls the power. Either way, magical access creates hierarchies – and those hierarchies can separate lovers by class, status, or allegiance.

YOUR ANSWER

What happens to someone who has magic but refuses or is unable to use it?

Does suppressed magic fester, leak out in uncontrolled ways, cause illness, or simply fade? The consequences of not using magic matter as much as the consequences of using it – especially if your character is hiding their abilities or has been forbidden from practising.

YOUR ANSWER

◆ **Core: How does magic change daily life for people who can't use it?**

Non-magical people still live in a magical world. Do they rely on enchanted tools, buy potions at market, avoid cursed areas, or resent the mages who control resources they can't access? The ordinary person's experience of magic shapes your world's texture and social tensions.

YOUR ANSWER

Cross-check: Does magical access match your class and political structure (Section 5)? If only certain bloodlines have magic, that should be reflected in who holds power. If anyone can learn magic, ask who controls the training, and whether that creates the same hierarchies you've built into your government.

Now that you know who has magic and how common it is, the next step is figuring out what it actually looks like when someone uses it.

How Magic Works

This is the mechanical heart of your system, the “physics” of magic. You don’t need to explain everything to readers, but you should understand how it operates so your story stays consistent. And the mechanics matter for romance too, because the process of using magic can strip away defences.

♦ **Core: How does someone actually do magic? What does the process look like?**

Spoken words, physical gestures, intense concentration, drawing symbols, channelling through objects, emotional states, rituals, physical contact, visualisation, music or art.

YOUR ANSWER

♦ **Core: What does magic look like when it happens?**

What do bystanders see, hear, or feel? Think about light, sound, temperature, smell, or a shift in the air.

YOUR ANSWER

♦ **Core: What does magic feel like to the person using it?**

Heat in the veins, pressure behind the eyes, a hum in the bones, a taste on the tongue? The internal sensation of casting is what makes magic feel real on the page. You’ll build on this in the “Magic Through the Body” section below, but sketch the basics now.

YOUR ANSWER

How long does it take to use magic, and does the time required change what's at stake?

Instant magic feels different from magic that requires preparation. A spell that takes thirty seconds of concentration means thirty seconds of vulnerability. A ritual that takes hours means hours of trust. Who do you let guard you while you work?

YOUR ANSWER

Can magic be interrupted? What happens if it's disrupted mid-use?

Interruptible magic creates vulnerability during casting, a moment when the powerful become defenceless. This is also a moment of trust: who do you let near you when you're mid-spell and exposed?

YOUR ANSWER

♦ **Core: What happens when magic goes wrong – misfires, backfires, or unintended effects?**

A miscast spell that scars the landscape, a healing that transfers the wound to someone else, a shield that traps the wrong person inside. Magical accidents reveal what your system does when it breaks, and that tells readers more about how it works than any successful casting.

YOUR ANSWER

What magical hazards exist in the environment?

Cursed zones, wild magic pockets, residue from old spells, corrupted ley lines, magical creatures that wander into settled areas. What dangers does magic create in the landscape that ordinary people have to navigate or avoid?

YOUR ANSWER

How predictable is your magic – and does the caster’s emotional state change that?

Magic that becomes volatile when the user is emotional is a romance goldmine. If your character’s control slips when they’re angry, frightened, or attracted, every charged moment becomes a potential magical incident.

YOUR ANSWER

Does using magic leave any lasting marks on the body – scars, changes in appearance, physical signs of power?

Glowing eyes, silver-streaked hair, branded palms, veins that darken during casting. Physical marks of magic make power visible and can become symbols of identity, stigma, or beauty depending on who’s looking.

YOUR ANSWER

Magic Through the Body

This is how you bring your magic system to life – by letting readers experience it through your character’s body. The heat in their veins, the pressure behind their eyes, the way their skin prickles when someone else’s power brushes against theirs. If you can’t describe what magic physically feels like to the person wielding it, your magic will read like stage directions rather than lived experience.

Romantasy authors use the same vocabulary for magic and attraction. Heat, pressure, breathlessness, thundering. And that overlap is deliberate. In *Fourth Wing*, Violet’s lightning signet first manifests during her first kiss with Xaden: the flash of light and boom of thunder are simultaneously the birth of her power and the peak of her arousal. In *ACOTAR*, Feyre describes her newly awakened magic as a ravaging hunger that builds as internal pressure until release is mandatory. And in *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy doesn’t just sense emotions. She tastes them. Chocolate and berries represent love. Anger is bitter. Fear is acidic. When Poppy is close to Hawke, what she “tastes” magically is completely indistinguishable from her physical attraction to him.

This overlap wasn’t incidental. It’s what makes romantic tension feel mythic rather than mundane. The less you make the burning desire for one another believable, the less the stakes will land. By making that burning a physical, magical sensation, you’re guaranteeing that the connection is felt at a biological level.

What does magic feel like in your character’s body, and how might those sensations overlap with attraction?

Romantasy uses the same vocabulary for magic and desire: heat, pressure, breathlessness, thundering. Violet’s lightning manifests during her first kiss. Poppy tastes emotions as flavours. Map your magic’s sensory profile, and pay attention to where those sensations could blur with physical attraction. That overlap is where romantic tension becomes mythic.

SENSE	WHAT MAGIC FEELS LIKE	WHEN IT INTENSIFIES
<i>Touch/Temperature</i>	<i>A scalding heat that starts in her chest and spreads outward</i>	<i>When she's angry or attracted, the heat becomes unbearable</i>
Touch/Temperature		
Sound		
Taste/Smell		
Internal pressure/sensation		
Visual (from the user's POV)		

Does using magic feel different when another person is involved, especially the love interest?

Magic that shifts when directed at or shared with another person creates a built-in intimacy barometer. In ACOTAR, the mating bond grows physically warm when acknowledged. In Fourth Wing, shared feelings bleed over as a scalp prickle and energetic pull. If your character's magic changes when the love interest is nearby, every charged moment has a magical signature.

YOUR ANSWER

What does overextension feel like, and how dangerous is it?

The physical symptoms of pushing too far should feel genuinely threatening, not just uncomfortable. In Fourth Wing, burnout manifests as trembling, fever, and skin that feels sunburned, and Violet's condition makes it life-threatening. What does pushing past the limit look like for your character, and why should readers be afraid when they reach for more power than their body can hold?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your character's emotional state change what magic feels like?

If magic is tied to emotion, falling in love might make it stronger, more volatile, or harder to control. Fear might suppress it. Grief might warp it. The connection between feeling and power is where romance and magic become inseparable, so map that connection now and you'll be able to use it in scenes later.

YOUR ANSWER



◆ Checkpoint: How Your Magic Works

Pause and look at your answers so far. Do the sensations you described for magic match the costs you outlined earlier? If using magic feels pleasurable but the cost is physical pain, make sure you know when the shift from one to the other happens. If something doesn't fit, adjust before moving on.

Training & Learning Magic

If your magic can be developed, taught, or improved upon, then you have to find someone to teach it. And training is one of the most reliable vehicles for romantic tension in the genre. Forced proximity. Physical contact. Power exchange. Vulnerability. The slow-burn satisfaction of watching someone grow into who they're meant to be. In *Fourth Wing*, nearly the entire first act is built around training. In *ACOTAR*, Rhysand teaching Feyre to shield her mind is the foundation of their intimacy. In *From Blood and Ash*, Hawke training Poppy to fight is what first cracks the walls of her sheltered existence.

Training accomplishes three things at once: physical closeness with a legitimate reason to interact, a power dynamic that must eventually be reversed, and forced vulnerability in a controlled setting. The mat session, the sparring ring, the mental shielding lesson – these are spaces where normal social rules are suspended.

The most interesting version of this trope uses the inherent teacher/student imbalance to contrast healthy and unhealthy models of power. In *ACOTAR*, Tamlin refuses to train Feyre and ultimately locks her in the manor; Rhysand insists she learn to shield her mind, teaches her to read, and provides tools for her autonomy. The training revealed which partner saw her as an equal and which saw her as something to protect. (*See the Power Imbalance section for more on how these dynamics play out.*)

How does your character learn or develop their magic?

Training is one of the most reliable vehicles for romantic tension in the genre. How your character learns shapes who they're close to, who has power over them, and what kind of vulnerability the learning demands. Formal instruction, self-taught experimentation, a mentor, trial by fire, institutional training, inherited knowledge?

YOUR ANSWER

Who teaches them? What is the power dynamic?

Teacher/student relationships carry inherent tension because one person holds knowledge and the other needs it. The most interesting version of this trope uses it to contrast healthy and unhealthy models of power: Tamlin's containment versus Rhysand's empowerment.

YOUR ANSWER

What does your character struggle with most in their training?

The thing your character finds hardest to master tells you something about who they are. A character who can't control their power has a different arc than one who can't access it. What specific skill, technique, or threshold is their biggest obstacle?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the training require physical proximity or contact?

Combat training, shared rituals, mental shielding, guided meditation, channelling through touch: any of these create a functional excuse for closeness that can become charged. The question isn't just whether they have to be near each other, but what that nearness forces them to feel.

YOUR ANSWER

What does the training environment look like?

A private sparring room feels different from a crowded academy hall. Where your characters train shapes what kind of intimacy the training allows, and what kind of witnesses might complicate things.

YOUR ANSWER

Training as Intimacy

Magical training creates a somatic awareness that easily slides into attraction. In *Fourth Wing*, Xaden's mat sessions force Violet into hyper-awareness of her own body and his. During the mental shielding lessons in *ACOTAR*, Feyre must expose her innermost thoughts to Rhysand. That friction – the necessity of openness before trust is established – is where tension lives.

The moment the student surpasses the teacher is one of the genre's definitive romantic turning points: the shift from hierarchy to partnership. Violet's lightning signet is so immense that Xaden admits she's the only one capable of killing him. Feyre uses the skills Rhysand taught her to demolish Tamlin's regime from within. Poppy transforms from Casteel's student to the Primal of Blood and Bone, and Casteel kneels.

At what point does your protagonist outgrow their teacher?

The moment the student surpasses the teacher is one of the genre's definitive romantic turning points, the shift from hierarchy to partnership. What triggers it? A crisis that demands more than what they were taught? An instinctive act their mentor couldn't replicate?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the love interest respond when they're surpassed?

This is a character test. Do they celebrate it, fear it, resent it, or kneel? In romantasy, the right partner is the one who sees your power and stands beside it rather than trying to contain it. Rhysand made Feyre High Lady. Xaden admitted Violet was the only one capable of killing him. Casteel knelt.

YOUR ANSWER

How does the relationship change once the student no longer needs the teacher?

The dynamic that began as "I'll teach you" needs to become "we teach each other" or "you don't need me anymore, but you still want me." The shift from need to choice is where the romance deepens.

YOUR ANSWER

The Cost

This is where your magic system really starts to get interesting. Unlimited power is dull; power with a price creates drama. What does magic take from the user, and is it worth paying?

When the cost of the magic is something that has been freely given as opposed to demanded, then the cost becomes romantic. When your character chooses to pay a price for someone else without being asked. So when you're writing this, show the cost through the body and through consequence, not through explanation. Don't tell readers that healing magic requires equivalent pain. Show the healer gritting their teeth. Show them bracing before they reach for someone's wound. Show them unable to stand afterwards. And when one character pays the price for another, let the witness react: the horror of watching someone you care about suffer for you, the guilt, the fury at not being asked first.

◆ Core: What does using magic cost?

Physical energy/exhaustion, pain/damage, shortened lifespan, emotional toll, rare materials, time, moral cost (corruption, debt), something from the world around them.

YOUR ANSWER

Does the cost scale with the power used?

Is a small spell a small price, while world-shaking magic demands everything?

YOUR ANSWER

♦ **Core: What happens when someone overextends, using more magic than they can safely handle?**

Overextension consequences create tension in high-stakes moments. What would your protagonist risk by pushing too far?

YOUR ANSWER

Is the cost immediate, or does it accumulate over time?

Can someone use magic freely for years and then pay all at once?

YOUR ANSWER

What does paying the cost look like from the outside?

Don't just know the cost – know how it shows. Does the caster's nose bleed? Do their hands shake? Does their hair go white at the temples? Do they age visibly? The physical evidence of magical cost is what makes it real for readers and for other characters watching.

YOUR ANSWER

Are there situational or plot-driven costs, times when magic can't be used safely?

In *ACOTAR*, Rhysand limits his magic use because the enemy can track it. Can magic be traced? Would using it alert enemies or violate a treaty? Does magic leave evidence?

YOUR ANSWER

Does your protagonist know the full cost of their power, or will they find out the hard way?

Hidden costs create devastating revelations. What might your protagonist discover about the price they've been paying, or will pay?

YOUR ANSWER

Hidden Costs and Secrets

Beyond the obvious costs, many abilities come with complications that characters want to hide. And secrets are fuel for romance.

What does your character's magic cost them that others can't easily see?

Physical toll, emotional burden, shortened lifespan, moral compromise?

YOUR ANSWER

Why do they hide this cost?

Shame, protection of others, fear of being seen as weak, fear of being stopped?

YOUR ANSWER

What would the love interest do if they discovered the hidden cost?

Would they try to stop your character, share the burden, or respect the choice?

YOUR ANSWER

What would your protagonist pay, magically, to protect someone they love?

When magic demands sacrifice, the most devastating moments come from one character paying a cost the other didn't ask for and can't repay. What price would your protagonist be willing to pay – and what would the person they paid it for feel about that choice?

YOUR ANSWER

Cross-check: Do healing capabilities match your technology section (Section 9)? If magical healing is common, your world may not need hospitals or advanced medicine. If it's rare or costly, medical infrastructure still matters. Make sure your technology reflects what magic can and can't fix.

The Limits

What your magic cannot do is just as important as what your magic can do. Limitations create tension, require creative thinking on the part of your characters and eliminate the ability for your characters to solve every problem with a simple wave of their hand. They also create romantic complications. In *The Cruel Prince*, the Fae can't lie. Every cruel thing Cardan says, Jude knows he means it. And every rare moment of honesty hits harder because she knows it's true; he literally can't say "I love you" unless he does.

♦ **Core: What is absolutely impossible with magic in your world? Name at least three things.**

Firm limitations prevent magic from solving every problem. What must your characters face without magical shortcuts?

Types of Magic Limitations

LIMITATION TYPE	EXAMPLES	STORY FUNCTION
Impossible Acts	Can't raise the dead, can't create love, can't time travel	Some problems must be solved without magic
Material Weaknesses	Iron disrupts fae, silver harms werewolves, salt breaks enchantments	Gives non-magical characters a chance
Environmental	Fails in certain locations/times	Creates dangerous/safe spaces
Physical State	Can't use when exhausted, injured, or emotional	Physical danger matters to mages

LIMITATION TYPE	EXAMPLES	STORY FUNCTION
Knowledge/Skill	Must learn abilities, years of training required	Creates expertise hierarchies
Resource Depletion	Energy runs out, components consumed, limited uses	Creates tactical decisions
Backlash	Overuse causes damage, failed magic backfires, corruption	Makes magical choices risky
Range/Scale	Only affects what you see/ touch, power diminishes with distance	Keeps magic personal
Countermeasures	Others can block/dispel, wards exist, immunities	Creates strategic depth
Social/Legal	Magic is illegal, regulated, taboo	External conflict beyond magic
Specificity	Fire mages can't do ice, each person has one gift	Requires teamwork
Consent/Will	Can't affect someone who truly resists	Protects character agency

Which limitation types exist in your system?

Every limitation creates story opportunities. Which constraints will force your characters to be creative, vulnerable, or dependent on others?

- ☐ Impossible Acts: _____
- ☐ Material Weaknesses: _____
- ☐ Environmental Limits: _____
- ☐ Physical State: _____
- ☐ Knowledge/Skill Caps: _____
- ☐ Resource Depletion: _____
- ☐ Backlash/Consequences: _____
- ☐ Range and Scale: _____
- ☐ Countermeasures: _____
- ☐ Social/Legal Limits: _____
- ☐ Specificity: _____
- ☐ Consent/Will: _____

What everyday problems does magic not solve?

Even in a magical world, some things remain hard. Does magic heal wounds but not grief? Grow crops but not end drought? Build walls but not trust? The gaps where magic falls short reveal what your characters and society still struggle with.

YOUR ANSWER

Are there things magic can technically do, but nobody attempts because the cost or risk is too high?

Forbidden-but-possible magic creates temptation. What might your protagonist be desperate enough to try?

YOUR ANSWER

How do non-magical people protect themselves from magic?

Wards, talismans, iron, salt, prayer, sheer willpower, hired mages, staying out of the way? The defences available to ordinary people shape how they feel about magic users – and whether your non-magical character has any real agency in a magical world.

YOUR ANSWER

What can't your characters do for each other because of magic's limits?

Think about what your leads would want to use magic for – protecting each other, healing each other, communicating across distance – and where the limits stop them. The things magic can't fix are often where the real emotional stakes live.

YOUR ANSWER



◆ Checkpoint: Cost and Limits

Pause and look at your answers so far. Can your protagonist solve their central problem with magic as you've defined it? If yes, your limits may need tightening. Do the costs you described create real hesitation, or would your character use magic freely without thinking twice? If something doesn't fit, adjust before moving on.



You know what magic costs and where it breaks down. Next, let's look at the range of power in your world and where your characters fall on that scale.

Scale, Power & Specialisations

Not all magic users are created equal, and not all magic is the same flavour. Understanding the range of power and the types of magic helps you place your characters and set stakes appropriately.

What does the weakest magic user in your world look like? What about the strongest?

Establishing the floor and ceiling of power helps you set stakes. If your protagonist is the most powerful being alive, tension has to come from somewhere other than “will they be strong enough?” If they’re among the weakest, every magical encounter is dangerous.

YOUR ANSWER

Where do your protagonist and love interest fall on this power scale?

Place both characters on the scale you defined above. See the Power Imbalance section for how this gap plays out in the relationship.

YOUR ANSWER

Is raw power the only measure of magical strength?

Or can skill, creativity, knowledge, or cleverness make a “weaker” user formidable?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the most impressive feat of magic in your world's history?

Legendary feats establish the ceiling of power in your world, and they often become the standard your characters are measured against. If your protagonist is being compared to the mage who shattered the mountain, that reputation affects how the love interest sees them.

Could anyone alive today replicate it?

YOUR ANSWER

Is magical power fixed, or can it grow?

How does someone become more powerful, and what do they risk in pursuing that growth?

YOUR ANSWER

Types and Specialisations

Is magic in your world one unified force, or are there distinct types, schools, or disciplines?

Different magical traditions can create cultural divides or opportunities for complementary partnership. If there are distinct types, list them.

YOUR ANSWER

Do magic users specialise, or can someone master multiple types?

What determines their speciality: birth, choice, training, or something else?

YOUR ANSWER

Are some types of magic considered more valuable, dangerous, or taboo than others?

Stigmatised magic creates secrets to hide or discover. Does either character possess abilities they must conceal?

YOUR ANSWER

Do different types of magic interact?

Can they combine for greater effect, cancel each other out, or create unexpected reactions?

YOUR ANSWER

How Your Leads' Magic Interacts

In *Gideon the Ninth*, Harrow is a necromancer who works with bones and death. Gideon is her cavalier, a swordswoman with no magic. The magic demands partnership; their history demands distance. The tension is about two people who are magically designed to be partners but emotionally unable to trust each other.

How might your leads' magic interact – where does it clash, and where does it complement?

This is a first sketch – we'll explore opposition and incompatibility in depth later. Describe each character's abilities, then think about what happens when those abilities meet. Do they amplify each other, cancel each other out, or create something unpredictable?

YOUR ANSWER

Magical Creatures, Familiars & Companions

If you have a magic system where creatures are bonded to individuals (dragons, familiars, spirit animals, daemons, shapeshifting) then your romance isn't just about two people. It's between two people and whatever magical beings are tethered to their souls. The creature bond often mirrors, facilitates, or complicates the romantic bond, and not using this relationship leaves a lot of the tension that makes the genre so great unexplored.

In *Fourth Wing*, the mating bond between Tairn and Sgaeyl forces their riders, Violet and Xaden, into proximity they can't escape. The dragons physically can't stay apart for more than a week. In *His Dark Materials*, touching another person's daemon is the ultimate taboo: a violation of the soul when done without consent, the deepest possible intimacy when chosen. In *ACOTAR*, beast forms externalise a character's raw nature, with Tamlin's territorial protector instincts made literal in fur and antlers.

This creature isn't just decorative. It's an emotional truth-teller, a mirror of what the character is trying to hide, and very often the first being to realise that the lead characters are interested in each other before either of them is willing to admit it.

Whether the character likes it or not, the bonded creature reacts to the romantic partner. In *Fourth Wing*, Tairn takes on a grumpy-father-figure role, scrutinising Xaden's worthiness, while Sgaeyl is fiercely protective of Xaden and initially sceptical of Violet. In the *Inheritance Cycle*, Saphira is openly jealous of Eragon's attraction to Arya, demeaning Arya's appearance and seeing any romantic attachment as a threat to the integrity of the rider-dragon bond.

These actions add to the romance because they're a physical representation of how the protagonist feels but won't say. The creature growls when the protagonist is attracted, bristles when they're hurt, and softens when trust begins to form. It's a built-in lie detector that makes denial impossible.

CREATURE RESPONSE	WHAT IT REVEALS	ROMANTIC FUNCTION
Protectiveness/gatekeeping	The creature is testing the love interest's worthiness	Raises stakes: the partner must earn approval from more than just the protagonist
Jealousy	The creature fears being displaced or the bond being weakened	Creates a triangle dynamic the protagonist must navigate
Mirroring attraction	The creature physically responds to what the protagonist is feeling	Makes denial impossible; forces honesty

CREATURE RESPONSE	WHAT IT REVEALS	ROMANTIC FUNCTION
Acceptance	The creature recognises the partner as safe or worthy	Acts as magical validation of the relationship

Does your protagonist have a bonded creature?

What's the nature of the bond: mental link, soul bond, channelling conduit, symbiotic partnership? How much of themselves do they share with the creature? The deeper the bond, the harder it is to hide feelings from your creature, and from yourself.

YOUR ANSWER

How does the creature respond to the love interest?

Protectiveness, jealousy, curiosity, hostility, instant acceptance? The creature's reaction is often the first honest signal of how the protagonist really feels, before either character is willing to admit it. Does its response change over the course of the story?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the creature know things about the protagonist's feelings before the protagonist does?

Bonded creatures often function as emotional truth-tellers. Can the creature sense attraction, fear, or trust before the character is willing to acknowledge it? In Fourth Wing, the dragons' mating bond reveals the riders' feelings before either rider is ready to face them.

YOUR ANSWER

The Creature Bond Alongside the Romantic Bond

When both a romantic relationship and an animal bond are present, the two bonds create an entangled situation where there may be conflicting obligations of loyalty and privacy as well as potential for increased shared vulnerability. In *Fourth Wing*, Violet and Xaden's mental connection through their mated dragons means they can feel each other's emotions, sense each other's presence, and share mental images, often unintentionally. There's no hiding.

This creates unique romantic complications. The initial reluctance from Xaden to pursue his interest in Violet was due to uncertainty about what his true desires were versus those enhanced by the mating bond. Privacy becomes impossible when your dragon can broadcast your feelings to your rival's dragon. And the creature bond can be weaponised: Violet learns to use the mental link to send Xaden distracting psychic images, forcing him to confront feelings he's trying to repress.

In some systems, characters have the ability to take on beast forms or shapeshift, thus making an external representation of their internal selves. In *ACOTAR*, High Lords shift into beast forms that reflect their core character: Tamlin's territorial protector instincts become literal in his bear-wolf hybrid form, while Rhysand's monstrous scaled form represents the darkness he controls but despises.

A key aspect of accepting a partner's beast form is acceptance of all parts of who they are. A partner who flinches from the beast form is rejecting part of who the person is. A partner who reaches for them in that state? They're choosing the whole person.

Does your character have a beast form, shifting ability, or creature aspect?

What does it look like? What does it reveal about their nature? In ACOTAR, Tamlin's beast form reflects his territorial protector instincts; Rhysand's monstrous scaled form represents the darkness he controls but despises.

YOUR ANSWER

How does the love interest respond to this form?

Fear, fascination, acceptance, attraction? The response is a character test: a partner who flinches from the beast form is rejecting part of who the person is.

YOUR ANSWER

What would it mean for the love interest to accept or embrace the creature aspect?

This often functions as one of the story's key romantic turning points, the moment where "I love you" extends to "I love all of you, including the parts that aren't human."

YOUR ANSWER

Cross-check: Are these magical creatures consistent with your flora and fauna (Section 2)? If your world has bonded dragons, your ecosystems should account for apex predators of that scale. If familiars exist, are they drawn from species you've already established? Make sure your magical creatures fit the natural world you've built.

Magic & Identity

Magical transformation is a significant part of how your characters grow within the romantasy genre. Your characters' sense of self, their position in the world, their greatest fears and desires are all wrapped up in how they use their magic. When magic changes, so does the person wielding it. And when the person changes, so does the relationship.

This is why many of the most successful romantic arcs in the genre are built around magical transformation: gaining power, losing it, or discovering it was never what you thought. How your love interest responds to that transformation, whether they celebrate it, fear it, or try to contain it, is one of the clearest tests of whether a relationship will survive.

In ACOTAR, Feyre returns from Under the Mountain transformed from a mortal huntress into a High Fae with the powers of all seven courts. Tamlin's response is to contain that transformation. He refuses to train her, refuses to let her explore her new abilities, and ultimately locks her in the manor. He treats her new magic as a threat to the stability he craves. Rhysand responds by insisting Feyre learn about her abilities, giving her the title of High Lady (breaking 15,000 years of tradition), and treating her power as something to be celebrated rather than managed.

The same can be said throughout the genre. At first, Reid reacts to discovering Lou is a witch with horror; his entire identity is built on destroying her kind. Reid only allows their relationship to continue once he accepts that he himself is magically gifted and he chooses to join Lou in the realm of magic rather than asking her to abandon hers. In Throne of Glass, Rowan's bond with Aelin survives the loss of her fire because their partnership was built on character, not magical utility. He accepts her as a mortal queen, proving their love is deeper than what her power could do.

◆ Core: How does your love interest respond to your protagonist's magic?

This is one of the most revealing questions you can ask about your romance. A partner who fears the transformation often represents a desire for control. A partner who embraces it facilitates the protagonist's growth.

RESPONSE PATTERN	WHAT IT SIGNALS	EXAMPLE
Containment	The partner values stability over the protagonist's growth	Tamlin locking Feyre in the manor

RESPONSE PATTERN	WHAT IT SIGNALS	EXAMPLE
Empowerment	The partner values the protagonist's autonomy and potential	Rhysand insisting Feyre train and claim her title
Fear/Rejection	The partner can't reconcile the protagonist's magic with their worldview	Reid's initial horror at Lou's witchcraft
Acceptance after growth	The partner must change their own beliefs to accept the magic	Reid choosing to follow Lou into the magic

Magical Transformation and the Romance

The changes your main character undergoes with regard to gaining, losing, or changing the way they practice magic can significantly affect the development of the romance. It has to, because the person your love interest fell for is no longer exactly the same person.

One of the genre's most common and powerful tropes is the prescient partner who recognises what the protagonist is before the protagonist does. Rhysand sees Feyre's power long before she claims it. Xaden recognises Violet's lethality when she still doubts herself. Seeing the fullness of another's potential is an act of romantic devotion, but it also raises questions. Does seeing someone's potential grant you authority over their growth, or is it a gift that must be offered without strings?

Magic lost in romantasy is typically used as a test of whether the love was based upon true affection or the magic that drew the two individuals together. When Aelin sacrifices most of her fire to seal the gate between worlds, Rowan's continued devotion proves their bond was forged on shared purpose and character, not magical utility. Even if your protagonist never loses their magic, readers are interested in finding out the answers to these questions.

The manner in which your character develops their magic influences the response from both the world and their partner. A character born into power occupies a different social position than one who gained it through trauma, transformation, or theft. In ACOTAR, Feyre's "Made" status (power given communally by all seven High Lords to save her life) creates political friction because it doesn't fit existing power structures. Tamlin views her transformation as a tragic byproduct; Rhysand views it as unprecedented hybrid potential.

How did your protagonist come by their magic?

Born with it, inherited it, earned it through training, gained it through trauma or transformation, had it forced upon them, stole it? The origin of your protagonist's power shapes how the world treats them, and how they feel about themselves.

YOUR ANSWER

Does the origin of their power affect how others treat them?

Born magic might be respected but expected. Gained magic might be feared, envied, or seen as illegitimate. Feyre's "Made" status creates political friction because it doesn't fit existing power structures. The social response to how someone got their power shapes the obstacles they face.

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a tension between what your protagonist was and what they're becoming?

The scribe becoming a rider. The mortal becoming Fae. The sheltered maiden becoming a warrior. These transitions force the character to negotiate between their past self and their emerging one, and the love interest is often the person who helps them bridge that gap, or the person who can't accept the change.

YOUR ANSWER

Hard Magic vs. Soft Magic

Hard Magic provides clear definitions, costs and limitations of a particular type of magic. So readers are always aware of what type of magic will work and what type will not, making the magic solution feel earned.

Soft Magic is ambiguous and not fully explained. It creates wonder and danger. However, the danger lies in using unexplained magic to solve large problems, which can feel like cheating.

Most romantasy falls somewhere in between, defined enough for stakes but mysterious enough for wonder. Where you land on this spectrum also affects how you write romantic magical moments. Using a hard magic system makes the deliberate gestures of intimacy feel chosen (he used exactly this spell, which costs exactly this much, for her). Soft magic systems make intimate moments feel wondrous and overwhelming (something happened between them that neither fully understands).

When writing hard magic, show the reader the rules through consequence. Don't explain that healing magic requires equivalent pain; show the healer gritting their teeth, show the price paid. When writing soft magic, maintain consistency in mood and limitation: if magic feels dangerous and unpredictable, keep that feeling and don't let it become convenient when you need it to be. In both cases, write magic through the body. The physical sensation of drawing power, the exhaustion after use, the way it feels to be on the receiving end.

Where does your magic fall on the spectrum?

Place your magic system on the spectrum. Mark it with an X or describe where it falls:

HARD (Clear rules, defined costs, readers can predict what magic will do) ←————→ SOFT
(Mysterious, wondrous, readers feel awe but can't predict outcomes)

YOUR ANSWER

Now answer the question that matches your position:

If your magic is on the harder side: Have you established the rules clearly enough that readers will accept magical solutions?

YOUR ANSWER

If your magic is on the softer side: Are you avoiding using vague magic to solve major plot problems?

YOUR ANSWER

If you're in the middle: Which elements are rule-bound and which are mysterious?

YOUR ANSWER

◆ Checkpoint: Magic and Identity

Pause and look at your answers so far. Does your protagonist's relationship to their magic match the transformation arc you're planning for them? If the love interest is meant to empower them, have you built in something the protagonist needs to grow into? If something doesn't fit, adjust before moving on.



You've defined what magic is, what it costs, and how it shapes who your characters are. Now let's look at how they actually use it with each other, in the small moments that build a private language.

Small Uses, Big Meaning

It's simple to identify grand magical gestures. The interesting stuff is smaller: the ways magic becomes part of a private language between two people. In *ACOTAR*, Rhysand uses his winnowing ability to send Feyre notes, appearing and disappearing paper and pen so they can have a private conversation across distance. Winnowing is transportation magic. There's nothing inherently romantic about it. The intimacy comes from the choice to use his power that way, to create something private that belongs only to them.

Look at the magic system you've already built. Don't add new "romantic" mechanics. Find the intimate potential in what exists.

What magic does your protagonist have?

List their abilities without thinking about romance yet.

YOUR ANSWER

Now: how could this magic be used to create a private moment?

A secret gesture? A communication no one else would notice or understand?

YOUR ANSWER

What about your love interest's magic?

What could they do with their abilities that would feel personal, specific, meant only for your protagonist?

YOUR ANSWER

What magical gesture would cost your character something – making it more meaningful?

The gesture matters more when it's difficult, costly, or unusual for the person doing it. A fire mage creating a gentle warmth. A warrior using their power to heal instead of destroy.

YOUR ANSWER

Now that you've identified what's possible, think about what becomes habitual: the gestures that start as one-offs and become part of your characters' private language.

What repeated small gesture might develop between your characters using their magic?

Think about: a fire mage who always keeps a candle lit in someone's window. An illusionist who makes small images appear to make the other laugh. A weather worker who clears the rain from just the space where someone's standing. A telekinetic who adjusts someone's collar without touching them.

YOUR ANSWER

What magical gesture would your characters recognise as meaningful that others would overlook or misunderstand?

Private meaning transforms ordinary magic into intimate language. What small act holds significance only for them?

YOUR ANSWER

How might your character's magic show care in a way that words wouldn't?

Especially if they're someone who struggles to express feelings directly:

YOUR ANSWER

Private Channels

One thing magic can do is create space for communication that exists outside normal channels. Not because the magic is telepathic, but because your characters find ways to use it that way.

Do your characters have any way of communicating that others can't easily intercept?

Enchanted objects passed back and forth, messages hidden in magical constructs, illusions only one person can see, a shared spell that signals without words.

YOUR ANSWER

What can they say through this channel that they couldn't say aloud or in public?

What makes this form of communication feel safer?

YOUR ANSWER

Did they create this private channel intentionally, or did it develop accidentally?

What does its origin say about their relationship?

YOUR ANSWER

Magic & Physical Intimacy

Your readers enjoy spicy romantasy. At some point, your characters are probably going to end up in bed (or against a wall, or in a hot spring). And when they do, their magic doesn't politely wait outside the door. It surges, breaks loose, amplifies, exposes, and transforms. That's the key difference between creating an intimate scene that belongs in your world versus one that could have been copied from any contemporary romance.

This isn't about writing explicit content for its own sake. It's about the fact that in your world your characters possess magical power inside of themselves and physical intimacy is the moment when that power is hardest to control. And control is what they've been maintaining all book. Losing control in an intimate encounter represents losing psychological control, and the magical consequences of that surrender raise the stakes beyond the personal.

When Violet and Xaden are finally together in *Fourth Wing*, her lightning signet discharges into the atmosphere, causing a literal storm. Windows shatter. Possessions break. The physical environment mirrors the emotional magnitude of what's happening between them. In *ACOTAR*, Rhysand's power manifests as tremors and vibrations that Feyre feels in her bones. In *A Court of Silver Flames*, Nesta's destructive silver fire simmers just beneath the surface during her encounters with Cassian, because the same power she refuses to learn to control is the power she can't contain when she finally lets someone close.

Across the board, the theme of the genre is the same: magic breaks its constraints when the character does. And this serves the story because it makes the intimate scene do narrative work. The lightning storm tells readers this relationship is seismic. The silver fire tells them Nesta's power and her trauma are two sides of the same coin when it comes to her capacity for connection. The magical discharge isn't decoration. It's characterisation.

What happens to your character's magic when they lose control emotionally or physically?

This is one of the genre's signature moments: the magical discharge during vulnerability. Fire mages set things ablaze. Shadow wielders darken the room. Empaths broadcast their emotions. What does your character's magic do when they can't hold it back?

YOUR ANSWER

Is the loss of magical control during intimacy dangerous?

Danger during vulnerability raises the stakes and forces trust. If your character's magic could genuinely hurt the person they're with, every intimate moment becomes an act of faith, from both sides.

YOUR ANSWER

What does the magical discharge reveal about the character?

The nature of the uncontrolled magic often reflects something true about the person wielding it. Fire for passion and destruction. Shadows for secrets and protection. Lightning for volatility and power. What does your character's magic say about them when they can't hold it back?

YOUR ANSWER

Shields, Glamours, and What Drops

Romantasy characters spend most of the story with their defences up: mental shields, glamours, emotional armour, magical concealment. Intimacy is the moment when those defences come down, and what's revealed underneath carries enormous narrative weight.

When Xaden and Violet have sex in *Fourth Wing*, his mental shields, usually impossible to penetrate, fall away, which means Violet can potentially access thoughts and memories he guards from everyone else. His shadows, which usually act as protection, instead wrap around her mind and intensify every sensation. Feyre touching

Rhysand's Illyrian wings in ACOTAR is the ultimate act of access. The wings are both his greatest weapon and his greatest vulnerability, and allowing her to touch them is surrendering his last defence. In A Court of Silver Flames, Nesta's psychological glamour, the ice queen persona she uses to keep everyone at a distance, is what finally cracks during her encounters with Cassian. He sees her unguarded, and that visibility is more intimate than anything physical.

As a general rule, in romantasy, magical bonds form at times when characters are at their most vulnerable. The timing isn't coincidental. The bond snaps into place at the exact moment when the characters have reached their most open emotionally and physically, so that they'll accept it.

The mating bond between Feyre and Rhysand in ACOTAR has been slowly developing throughout the majority of the story, but it fully clicks into place during a moment of profound emotional and physical openness. After accepting the bond, Feyre's creativity reawakens, and she begins to paint again. The bond isn't just romantic; it restores something in her that trauma had destroyed. In From Blood and Ash, the deepening of Poppy and Casteel's connection is tied to the Atlantian bite, a biological mechanic where saliva containing primal magic causes intense euphoria. For Atlantians, feeding from a partner they care about is sacred. The act of biting transforms from something predatory (the Ascended) into something intimate (Casteel), and the magical biology draws a moral line between the antagonists and the love interest.

Does physical intimacy activate, deepen, or change any magical connection between your characters?

A bond snapping into place, a mark appearing, powers amplifying, a mental link opening: many of the genre's most pivotal moments happen when physical and magical vulnerability collide.

YOUR ANSWER

If so, is this activation wanted or feared?

A bond that activates during intimacy can feel like cosmic confirmation, or like the universe making a choice the characters didn't get to make consciously. The difference shapes whether the moment feels like a gift or a trap.

YOUR ANSWER

Sensation Amplification

Romantasy authors often employ magical biology in order to separate their characters' romantic encounters from ordinary human ones. In *Fourth Wing*, the mental bond between Violet and Xaden creates a sensory feedback loop during intimacy. They can almost supernaturally sense each other's desire, and sensation is transmitted and amplified between them. In *From Blood and Ash*, the euphoric bite is a biological mechanic that makes Poppy's first experience with Casteel so overwhelming it shatters her preconceptions about who he is.

While these amplification mechanics seem gratuitous, they actually serve the story by making the intimate connection feel as extraordinary as the world these characters inhabit. The magical sensation distinguishes this relationship from anything either character has experienced before, reinforcing the idea that this connection is singular.

The line between magic that serves the story and magic that's just spectacle is whether the intimate scene would lose narrative meaning if you removed the magical elements. Would anything important be lost if the lightning storm didn't happen, the shield didn't drop, the bond wasn't activated, or the empathic verification wasn't there? If yes, the magic is doing its job. If the scene works exactly the same without it, the magic is decoration.

The best method is to treat intimate scenes the same way you treat any other scene where magic is present: the magic should create consequences, reveal character, or advance the plot. Trust earned when shields dropped. A bond that now creates new obligations. A loss of control that has political or magical fallout. Power that has shifted between the characters because of what was shared.

Does your magic system include any sensation amplification, a mechanic that makes intimate connection feel different from ordinary experience?

A sensory feedback loop, empathic sharing, a euphoric biological mechanic, amplified awareness through a bond: these aren't gratuitous. They make the intimate connection feel as extraordinary as the world your characters inhabit. If your system includes something like this, define it. If it doesn't, that's fine; skip ahead.

YOUR ANSWER

If so, would the intimate scene lose narrative meaning if you removed the magical element? What would be missing?

This is the test for whether the magic is serving the story or just decorating it. If the scene works exactly the same without the lightning storm, the shield drop, or the bond activation, the magic is spectacle. If something important would be lost, the magic is earning its place.

YOUR ANSWER

After your characters' intimate scene, what has changed magically?

The best intimate scenes in romantasy aren't just emotional milestones; they're plot events. Something magical should be different afterwards that can't be undone.

New bond, deepened connection, revealed secret, shifted power dynamic, consequence that can't be undone?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the magical element create aftermath that affects the plot?

Other characters noticing the bond, magical evidence that can't be hidden, a power shift that changes the political landscape: the intimate scene should send ripples outward.

YOUR ANSWER

Bonds, Marks & Fated Connection

Some magic systems include mechanics that directly link characters: mating bonds, soul marks, fated recognition, shared senses, dream connections. These tropes are popular because they offer certainty in a genre built on “will they?” But that certainty is also the greatest threat. The best versions treat the bond as a complication, not a conclusion. The magic might say they’re matched, but it doesn’t make them compatible, resolve their conflicts, or build trust. It merely increases the difficulty of walking away.

If your magic system doesn’t include bonds or fated connections, skip ahead to Dangerous, Forbidden & Hunted Magic.

The Mechanics

Get the mechanics clear first – a bond that’s biological works differently than one that’s divine – and the romantic implications will follow.

What is the bond, fundamentally? What kind of phenomenon is it?

Biological (pheromones, genetic compatibility)? Magical (a spell, curse, enchantment)? Divine (granted by gods, written in fate)? Spiritual (souls recognising each other)? Something your world doesn’t fully understand?

YOUR ANSWER

How does a bond form? What triggers it?

Exists from birth? Snaps at first meeting/touch? Requires ritual or vow? Builds gradually? Can be created deliberately or only happens spontaneously?

YOUR ANSWER

Is the bond universal in your world, or rare?

Does everyone have a fated mate? Only certain bloodlines or species? Common enough for social customs, or rare enough they don't believe it at first?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the bond follow the same rules as the rest of your magic?

Same costs, same limitations – or does it operate outside normal magical laws? A bond that breaks the rules of your system needs a reason, or it risks feeling bolted on.

YOUR ANSWER

How much does your world understand about how bonds work?

Is the mechanism well-studied and documented? Shrouded in mystery and legend? Actively suppressed or hidden? Do your characters have accurate information, or will they discover that what they believed about bonds is wrong?

YOUR ANSWER

What kinds of magical connection exist between people in your world?

Mating bonds, soul marks, fated mate recognition through scent or sight, telepathic links, shared sensory experiences, dream-walking, magical contracts – list whatever applies.

YOUR ANSWER

What does the bond actually do? Be specific about the mechanics.

Physical pull? Emotional awareness? Telepathy? Pain when separated? Recognition? Sexual compatibility?

YOUR ANSWER

What is the bond unable to do?

It might create attraction but not trust. Recognition but not compatibility. Awareness but not understanding.

What gaps remain even with this connection?

YOUR ANSWER

Destiny vs. Choice

The core tension: readers want to believe the couple belongs together, but they also want to know the characters chose. The sweet spot is usually that the bond creates the opportunity or the pull, but the relationship requires choice.

In your world, is the bond a compulsion, an invitation, or something in between?

A compulsion leaves no room for choice. An invitation can be refused. Most interesting bonds live somewhere in the middle.

YOUR ANSWER

Can the bond be rejected, resisted, or refused? What does that cost?

Physical pain? Shortened lifespan? Loss of power? Endless longing? Social consequences? Nothing at all?

YOUR ANSWER

Has anyone in your world rejected a bond? What happened to them?

Stories of rejection establish stakes. Do cautionary tales make your characters more afraid, or more determined to resist?

YOUR ANSWER

If your characters could walk away from the bond without consequence, would they still choose each other?

At what point in the story does this become true?

YOUR ANSWER

When the Bond Reveals Itself

Timing changes everything. A bond recognised at first meeting creates different tension than one that emerges after feelings already exist.

When do your characters become aware of the bond?

Before they have feelings for each other, or after?

YOUR ANSWER

If the bond comes first: How do your characters interpret their growing feelings?

Do they trust what they feel, or wonder if it's just the magic?

YOUR ANSWER

If feelings come first: How does discovering the bond change things?

Confirmation or stolen choice? One validated while the other feels trapped?

YOUR ANSWER

Do both characters discover the bond at the same time?

Or does one know before the other? What does this asymmetry create?

YOUR ANSWER

The Inconvenient Bond

The most compelling bonds are in direct conflict with everything else in the characters' lives – circumstances, history, politics, or personality pushing them apart while the magic pulls them together.

What makes this bond inconvenient, unwanted, or complicated for your protagonist?

The love interest is an enemy, rival, captor, wrong species, wrong class, already committed, politically dangerous, personally infuriating, someone who hurt them or their people.

YOUR ANSWER

What makes it inconvenient for your love interest?

Both characters should have reasons to resist. What does the love interest stand to lose by accepting this connection?

YOUR ANSWER

What would your characters lose by accepting the bond?

Position, freedom, other relationships, sense of self, life goals?

YOUR ANSWER

Are they resisting the bond itself, or what accepting it would mean for their lives?

ARE THEY RESISTING THE BOND ITSELF, OR WHAT ACCEPTING IT WOULD MEAN FOR THEIR LIVES?

The Work the Bond Doesn't Do

A bond might guarantee compatibility on some level, but it doesn't build a relationship. These questions help you identify what your characters still have to earn.

What does the bond not give your characters that they still have to build the hard way – and what old wounds might it reopen?

The bond might create attraction and recognition, but it can't make two people truly know each other, agree with each other, or forgive each other. And a bond that forces closeness can make existing injuries worse: a character who fears abandonment now has a connection they can't escape; a character who fears control now has a tie they didn't choose.

YOUR ANSWER

If you've answered the questions above, you have a solid foundation for how your bond works, what it means, and what it can't do. The remaining questions explore how the bond interacts with the wider world and when your characters choose each other. Answer what's useful. You can always come back!

Bonds in Context

Is the bond visible to others?

Can people see the mark, sense the connection, or recognise bonded pairs?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your society view bonded pairs?

Reverence, envy, suspicion, obligation, legal recognition, political value?

YOUR ANSWER

Is their specific bond acceptable, or does who they're bonded to create scandal?

IS THEIR SPECIFIC BOND ACCEPTABLE, OR DOES WHO THEY'RE BONDED TO CREATE SCANDAL?

Can the bond be hidden, and what happens if it's discovered?

What would your characters have to do to conceal the connection – and who would be most threatened by finding out?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the bond give one character more power than the other?

Maybe one can sense the other's emotions but not vice versa, or one can close the bond while the other can't. Asymmetrical bonds create power dynamics that mirror the broader relationship – and that imbalance needs to be addressed, or it becomes a form of control. How does the character with less access push back?

YOUR ANSWER

Can the bond be used against one of the characters?

Could an enemy exploit the connection?

YOUR ANSWER

Can one character shut down their end of the bond? What would the other feel?

Closing the bond – if it's possible – can be an act of self-protection or a weapon. Either way, the silence where connection used to be tells its own story.

YOUR ANSWER

The Choice Moment

The most satisfying romantic payoff comes when characters choose each other not because the magic compels them, but because they want this, consequences and all.

At what point do your characters stop fighting the bond and start choosing each other? What changes?

AT WHAT POINT DO YOUR CHARACTERS STOP FIGHTING THE BOND AND START CHOOSING EACH OTHER? WHAT CHANGES?

What does choosing look like – and if the bond disappeared tomorrow, would they still stay?

Is there a moment, a declaration, an action that marks the shift from “stuck with this” to “I want this”? At what point in your story does this become true regardless of the bond?

YOUR ANSWER

If you removed every magical link between your characters, would they still have reasons to be drawn to each other?

This is the agency test. Compelled connection may feel intense, but chosen connection reveals character. What non-magical reasons exist for this relationship?

YOUR ANSWER

◆ **Checkpoint: Bonds and Connection**

Pause and look at your answers so far. If you have a bond mechanic, does it follow the same rules as the rest of your magic, or does it operate separately? Does the bond create tension that the characters have to work through, or does it resolve the romance too easily? If something doesn't fit, adjust before moving on.

Dangerous, Forbidden & Hunted Magic

A relationship based on fear of being hurt by the magic, fear of the consequences of being discovered, and the risk of letting someone close enough to see what you really are is automatically filled with built-in romantic tension.

To write dangerous magic well, you should demonstrate your character's physical awareness of their power at all times. The way they hold themselves still. The reflexive clenching when emotions spike. The careful distance they maintain. Show the reader how many near-misses have happened: the glass that cracks, the temperature drop, the flicker of something wrong that the character quickly suppresses.

In *Shatter Me*, Juliette's lethal touch means she can kill anyone who makes skin contact. The entire romance is built on the question of who can survive touching her, and what it means when someone can. The tension builds as the partner moves closer while the dangerous one backs away. When the dangerous character finally allows the partner to touch them during a moment of extreme emotion, this is a pivotal moment in the story. They're choosing trust over safety.

Is your character's magic dangerous to others? To themselves? To both?

IS YOUR CHARACTER'S MAGIC DANGEROUS TO OTHERS? TO THEMSELVES? TO BOTH?

Can this danger be managed with training, or is it built into the magic itself?

What does "control" look like on a good day, and what does losing control look like on a bad one?

YOUR ANSWER

Has your character ever hurt someone with their magic?

What happened, and how did it shape their relationship to their power?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the fear of causing harm affect how your character lets people close?

What protective distance do they maintain, and what would make them risk closing it?

YOUR ANSWER

What would the love interest have to do or say to convince your character that the risk is worth taking?

WHAT WOULD THE LOVE INTEREST HAVE TO DO OR SAY TO CONVINCE YOUR CHARACTER THAT THE RISK IS WORTH TAKING?

Forbidden or Hunted Magic

Writing about concealed magic is all about the constant low-level dread of hiding. Show the daily cost: the way your character monitors every word, every gesture, every instinctive reach for power that has to be suppressed. Show what they do instead of using magic. The workarounds, the lies, the exhausting performance of being ordinary.

The romantic turning point isn't the dramatic reveal; it's the moment just before it, when they decide this person is worth the risk of being known. In *Serpent & Dove*, Lou hides her witchcraft from Reid, who is literally a witch hunter. The tension isn't just "will he find out?" It's "what happens to us when he does?"

Is your character's magic forbidden, illegal, or socially condemned?

What are the consequences of being discovered: execution, imprisonment, exile, experimentation?

YOUR ANSWER

Who knows about their abilities? Who absolutely can't find out?

WHO KNOWS ABOUT THEIR ABILITIES? WHO ABSOLUTELY CAN'T FIND OUT?

What does your character have to do to hide their magic?

What daily deceptions, limitations, or sacrifices does concealment require?

YOUR ANSWER

What would it mean to reveal their magic to the love interest?

What's the worst-case outcome they fear? What's the hope they might not admit to?

YOUR ANSWER

If the love interest discovered the truth by accident rather than being told, how would that affect trust?

The difference between confession and discovery can define whether secrets become intimacy or betrayal.

YOUR ANSWER

Magic Used Against Will

The darkest magical conflicts involve power used without consent: abilities that can compel, manipulate, or control.

Can your character's magic be used against their will?

By whom and under what circumstances?

YOUR ANSWER

Can your character's magic affect others without their consent?

What are the ethical lines they've drawn, and have they ever crossed them?

YOUR ANSWER

What is the worst thing magic can do to a person in your world?

Mind control, soul theft, forced transformation, memory erasure – what does your character fear most, whether it's being done to them or something they could do to someone else?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens if one character uses magic on the other without permission?

Maybe it was for protection, or in desperation, or to get information they needed. Could the relationship survive it? What would repair require?

YOUR ANSWER

Opposition & Incompatibility

Do your characters' magical abilities conflict?

What happens when they're used in close proximity: cancellation, amplification, volatility, pain?

YOUR ANSWER

Can this magical opposition be overcome, or is it permanent?

If it can be overcome, what would it take – practice, trust, sacrifice, or something else entirely?

YOUR ANSWER

Does their magical conflict match their personal dynamic, or contradict it?

Sometimes characters whose magic clashes are also opposites in temperament – fire and ice, in every sense. Other times, the magical conflict is at odds with how well they actually get along. Which version creates more interesting tension for your story?

YOUR ANSWER

If their magic is dangerous to combine, what circumstances might force them to try anyway? What would be worth the risk?

IF THEIR MAGIC IS DANGEROUS TO COMBINE, WHAT CIRCUMSTANCES MIGHT FORCE THEM TO TRY ANYWAY? WHAT WOULD BE WORTH THE RISK?

Power Imbalance

You sketched the basics of your power gap in the “Who Can Use Magic” section. Now let’s dig deeper into how that imbalance plays out.

Is there a significant power gap between your characters? Who holds more magical, political, or physical power?

IS THERE A SIGNIFICANT POWER GAP BETWEEN YOUR CHARACTERS? WHO HOLDS MORE MAGICAL, POLITICAL, OR PHYSICAL POWER?

What does the more powerful character have that the other wants or needs?

Think about what they could give freely – and what they could withhold.

YOUR ANSWER

What does the less powerful character have that the powerful one lacks?

Knowledge, skills, connections, immunity, moral clarity, the ability to say no – power isn’t just magic.

YOUR ANSWER

How does the power balance shift throughout your story? What moments give the less powerful character the upper hand?

HOW DOES THE POWER BALANCE SHIFT THROUGHOUT YOUR STORY? WHAT MOMENTS GIVE THE LESS POWERFUL CHARACTER THE UPPER HAND?

What would an outsider see when watching your characters together?

Would they be concerned? Would they be right to be? Sometimes a power imbalance looks worse from the outside than it is – and sometimes it looks better.

YOUR ANSWER

Oaths, Debts & Binding Agreements

A large number of fantasy worlds contain magic which binds the words of those who use it. Bargains, oaths, contracts. These bindings create obligations that can trap characters into making choices they can't live up to, and they're one of the most versatile tools for romantic tension.

Feyre's bargain with Rhysand in *ACOTAR* requires her to spend one week per month in the Night Court. At first glance, it seems like a terrible thing: a powerful male claiming a human woman's time against her will. But the requirement to spend time in the Night Court becomes the catalyst for the real romance. It forces proximity, creates a space away from Tamlin, and gives Feyre a reason to keep returning to the person she's actually falling for. What appeared to be a cage created by the magic was in reality an opportunity for escape.

What promises in your world are magically enforced?

What happens when they're broken?

YOUR ANSWER

Is your character bound by any magical oath or agreement?

What are the terms, and who holds the other end?

YOUR ANSWER

Does this binding create an obstacle to the romance?

Something they've promised that conflicts with what they want?

YOUR ANSWER

Could a magical bargain be used for the romance?

A binding that protects, legitimises, or forces proximity? What would the terms be, and who would propose it?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the most dangerous promise your character could make? What would push them to make it?

Love makes people offer things they shouldn't. What would your protagonist risk for the one they love?

YOUR ANSWER

Magic in Your Plot

You've built the system. Now let's make sure it actually works for the story you're telling, both the plot and the romance.

How does magic create or complicate your central conflict?

Not just "there's a magical villain," but how do the rules of your magic shape what's possible?

YOUR ANSWER

What can your antagonist do with magic that makes them a genuine threat?

What limits prevent them from simply winning immediately?

YOUR ANSWER

Act 1: Setup

In *ACOTAR*, Feyre kills a faerie, a magical creature, in the woods. The inciting incident isn't just "something happens"; it's "something magical happens that she can't undo."

What magical event, ability, or consequence pulls your protagonist out of their ordinary world?

The inciting incident often involves magic working in ways the protagonist didn't expect or couldn't control.

YOUR ANSWER

How does this same magical event connect them to the love interest?

In romantasy, the fantasy inciting incident and the meet-cute should be linked.

YOUR ANSWER

Act 2: Rising Action

What magical obstacles, revelations, or complications arise as your leads grow closer?

Magic should complicate the romance as much as it complicates the plot. Secrets about power, dangerous abilities, conflicting duties.

YOUR ANSWER

Does magic create intimacy or distance as they grow closer?

Shared power, training together, magical bonds forming? Or secrets, power imbalances, dangerous abilities?

YOUR ANSWER

Act 3: Crisis

What magical crisis makes everything seem hopeless?

How does magic trap, separate, or endanger your leads at their lowest point?

YOUR ANSWER

Act 4: Resolution

In *ACOTAR*, Feyre solves Amarantha's riddle, and the answer is love. Her willingness to die for Tamlin breaks the curse. The romantic sacrifice triggers the magical solution. The romantic climax IS the magical climax.

How does your protagonist's romantic choice enable the magical resolution?

In the best romantasy, love isn't separate from magic. The emotional climax and the magical climax should intertwine.

YOUR ANSWER

What is your protagonist's magical state at the end versus the beginning?

Gained power, lost it, transformed, or learned to use it differently?

YOUR ANSWER

◆ Checkpoint: Magic in Your Plot

Pause and look at your answers so far. Does the magical crisis in your climax grow naturally from the rules, costs, and limits you established earlier? If your resolution requires magic to do something you said it couldn't, either revise the resolution or revise the limitation. If something doesn't fit, adjust before moving on.

Magic and Romance: Synthesis

You've built your magic from every angle. Before moving on, pull your answers together into one place. If any row is blank, flip back to the relevant section.

ELEMENT	YOUR ANSWER (PULL FROM EARLIER SECTIONS)
<i>Source: where does magic come from?</i>	
<i>Access: who can use it, and who can't?</i>	
<i>Cost: what does it take from the user?</i>	
<i>Biggest limitation: what can't it do?</i>	
<i>How it connects your leads</i>	
<i>How it divides your leads</i>	

ELEMENT	YOUR ANSWER (PULL FROM EARLIER SECTIONS)
<i>How it affects the romance</i>	
<i>What does closeness look like without magic?</i>	

Looking at the table above, where is the strongest tension between what magic gives your characters and what it costs them – romantically?

LOOKING AT THE TABLE ABOVE, WHERE IS THE STRONGEST TENSION BETWEEN WHAT MAGIC GIVES YOUR CHARACTERS AND WHAT IT COSTS THEM -- ROMANTICALLY?

What does the love interest notice about the protagonist's magic that others overlook?

Seeing what others miss is a form of intimacy. What do they perceive about how the protagonist wields power that reveals how closely they watch?

YOUR ANSWER

What would it mean for your protagonist to show the love interest a side of their magic no one else sees?

Full power, raw vulnerability, a secret ability – letting someone see your magic unguarded is one of the genre’s deepest forms of intimacy. It’s about trusting them with the parts of yourself you normally keep hidden.

YOUR ANSWER

Magic in Your World

Magic doesn't just affect your characters. It shapes the larger world they live in, and that world exerts its own pressure on their relationship. Wars fought over magical resources. Political systems built on magical hierarchy. Environmental damage from centuries of spellwork. These aren't personal conflicts, but they create the conditions your characters must navigate, and often force impossible choices between love and duty, safety and conscience, each other and everyone else.

♦ **Core: How has magic shaped the power structures in your world? Who's on top because of magic, and who's at the bottom?**

Magical hierarchy creates the conditions your characters must navigate. If your leads come from different levels of this hierarchy, the world itself is pushing against their relationship.

YOUR ANSWER

What do non-magical people think of magic users? Fear? Reverence? Resentment? Envy? Exploitation?

Public attitudes toward magic affect whether your characters can be open about who they are and what they can do. If one character is magical and the other isn't, public opinion may be the biggest obstacle they face.

YOUR ANSWER

Magical Resources and Scarcity

Does magic in your world require resources that can be controlled, hoarded, or fought over?

Rare plants, minerals, or creatures. Ley lines or places of power. Magical artefacts. Blood or life force. Access to training, texts, or teachers.

YOUR ANSWER

Who controls magical resources in your world? Who's excluded from access?

If one character controls something the other desperately needs, every interaction between them carries an undercurrent of dependence and obligation, which can look a lot like attraction from the outside.

YOUR ANSWER

Are there active conflicts over magical resources – wars, trade disputes, political manoeuvring?

How do these affect ordinary people who have no magic of their own?

YOUR ANSWER

How might resource scarcity put pressure on your leads?

Consider: they're on opposite sides of a resource conflict, one of them controls something the other desperately needs, their relationship threatens existing power structures, or staying together requires resources they can't access.

YOUR ANSWER

Magical Damage and Corruption

Has magic damaged your world, and is that damage spreading, stable, or being healed?

Corrupted lands, scarred populations, broken ecosystems. Magical catastrophe creates the backdrop your characters live against. What would it take to fix the damage, and what would that cost?

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters live with the consequences of magical damage? How does it affect their daily lives, their communities, their futures?

DO YOUR CHARACTERS LIVE WITH THE CONSEQUENCES OF MAGICAL DAMAGE? HOW DOES IT AFFECT THEIR DAILY LIVES, THEIR COMMUNITIES, THEIR FUTURES?

Could magical corruption threaten your characters directly: their home, their people, their health, their powers?

COULD MAGICAL CORRUPTION THREATEN YOUR CHARACTERS DIRECTLY: THEIR HOME, THEIR PEOPLE, THEIR HEALTH, THEIR POWERS?

How might magical damage or corruption put pressure on your leads' relationship?

Consider: one character caused the damage, or comes from the people who did. Healing the corruption requires a sacrifice one of them isn't willing to make. The damaged land is the only place they're safe together, or the one place they can't go.

YOUR ANSWER

Magical Arms Races

Is there military or political competition to develop magical power in your world?

Nations racing to train war-mages. Factions seeking ancient weapons. Attempts to breed more powerful magic users.

YOUR ANSWER

What's the most dangerous magical weapon or capability in your world? Who has it, and who wants it?

WHAT'S THE MOST DANGEROUS MAGICAL WEAPON OR CAPABILITY IN YOUR WORLD? WHO HAS IT, AND WHO WANTS IT?

Are your characters caught up in this competition? As weapons, as soldiers, as prizes, as targets?

ARE YOUR CHARACTERS CAUGHT UP IN THIS COMPETITION? AS WEAPONS, AS SOLDIERS, AS PRIZES, AS TARGETS?

How does the magical arms race affect your characters personally?

Consider: one or both are seen as weapons rather than people, their abilities make them too valuable for factions to release, falling in love creates a vulnerability enemies can exploit, or their duties put them on opposite sides.

YOUR ANSWER

Regulation, Control, and Resistance

How does authority in your world attempt to control magic?

Registration of magic users. Licensing and restriction. Conscription of powerful mages. Suppression of “dangerous” types. State monopoly on training.

YOUR ANSWER

Who benefits from magical regulation? Who suffers under it?

WHO BENEFITS FROM MAGICAL REGULATION? WHO SUFFERS UNDER IT?

Is there resistance to magical control?

Underground magic users, rebel factions, hidden communities, black markets?

YOUR ANSWER

Where does your protagonist stand in relation to magical authority – hunted, enforcer, exempt, hidden?

And where does the love interest stand? If one enforces the rules and the other breaks them, every interaction carries risk. If both are on the same side, what would it take to push them apart?

YOUR ANSWER

History Repeating

What major magical conflict shaped your world's recent history, and how does it still affect the present?

A war, a catastrophe, a revolution. What resentments, imbalances, or unfinished business remain? The past rarely stays buried, and inherited conflicts create some of the most powerful romantic obstacles.

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters come from different sides of this historical divide?

Inherited enmity creates powerful tension when attraction crosses lines generations have drawn.

YOUR ANSWER

What would it take to truly resolve the old conflict?

Is resolution possible within your story, or is this the wound your world carries? Some conflicts can be healed; others can only be survived.

YOUR ANSWER

If your characters are from different sides of this divide, what does choosing each other cost them in the eyes of their own people?

Inherited enmity makes love feel like betrayal, not of the partner, but of everyone who came before. What do your characters risk from their own side by being together?

YOUR ANSWER

The Bigger Pressure

What external magical conflict puts the most pressure on your leads' relationship?

Wars, political upheaval, magical catastrophe: the world doesn't pause for love. Identifying the external pressure helps you write the impossible choices that make romantasy heartbreaking.

YOUR ANSWER

At some point, will your characters have to choose between each other and the larger conflict? What does that choice look like?

The best romantasy forces this choice and then finds a way to make both matter. What does your version of "save the world or save the person you love" look like?

YOUR ANSWER

If they ignore the world's problems to be together, what happens? Can they live with the consequences?

Some of the most devastating romantic moments come from characters trying to have both, saving the world and keeping each other, and failing. What happens in the gap between what they want and what they can have?

YOUR ANSWER

*If they sacrifice their relationship to address the world's problems, what happens?
Would either of them actually make that choice?*

IF THEY SACRIFICE THEIR RELATIONSHIP TO ADDRESS THE WORLD'S PROBLEMS, WHAT
HAPPENS? WOULD EITHER OF THEM ACTUALLY MAKE THAT CHOICE?

Magic and Death

What happens to magic at the boundary of life and death affects everything from grief to resurrection to the ultimate romantic sacrifice.

What happens to a person's magic when they die? Does it dissipate, transfer, linger, or become something else?

If magic persists after death – as ghosts, residue, or inherited power – it shapes how your world mourns, remembers, and fears the dead.

YOUR ANSWER

Can magic interact with death or undead? Can the dead be raised, communicated with, or bound? If so, what are the costs and taboos? Necromancy-adjacent magic raises questions your romance may need to answer: would your protagonist bring back the person they love? At what price?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the possibility (or impossibility) of magical resurrection affect the stakes of your story?

HOW DOES THE POSSIBILITY (OR IMPOSSIBILITY) OF MAGICAL RESURRECTION AFFECT THE STAKES OF YOUR STORY?

Magical Law Enforcement

If magic can break laws, someone has to enforce them. How magical crimes are handled shapes the danger your characters face and the authority structures they navigate.

How are magical crimes investigated? Is there a specialised force, or do ordinary authorities handle magic?

HOW ARE MAGICAL CRIMES INVESTIGATED? IS THERE A SPECIALISED FORCE, OR DO ORDINARY AUTHORITIES HANDLE MAGIC?

What counts as a magical crime in your world – and what punishments exist?

Unauthorised magic, magical assault, forbidden spells, unlicensed practice? The line between legal and illegal magic tells you where your characters are safe and where they're vulnerable.

YOUR ANSWER

Could your protagonist or love interest be arrested, hunted, or prosecuted for how they use their magic?

COULD YOUR PROTAGONIST OR LOVE INTEREST BE ARRESTED, HUNTED, OR PROSECUTED FOR HOW THEY USE THEIR MAGIC?

Magical Healing

Healing magic is one of the most story-relevant abilities in romantasy because it intersects directly with vulnerability, sacrifice, and care. Define its scope now so it doesn't become a convenient fix later.

What can healing magic do, and what can't it do?

Can it mend bones but not cure disease? Heal wounds but not regrow limbs? Repair the body but not the mind? The limits of healing determine what your characters must endure and what they can spare each other from.

YOUR ANSWER

Who has access to healing magic – and who doesn't?

Is healing common or rare? Free or expensive? Controlled by institutions, available to anyone with the gift, or hoarded by the powerful? Access to healing is a measure of power in your world.

YOUR ANSWER

What does healing cost the healer?

In From Blood and Ash, Poppy absorbs others' pain into herself. A healer who pays a price for every life they save faces different choices than one who heals freely. What does your healer risk?

YOUR ANSWER

Non-Human Magic

If your world includes multiple species or races, their experience of magic may differ fundamentally from human magic. These differences create cultural divides, misunderstandings, and the friction that makes cross-species romance compelling.

Do different species experience or use magic differently?

Fae magic might be innate and instinctive where human magic is learned and effortful. Dragon magic might be elemental where elvish magic is linguistic. What are the key differences?

YOUR ANSWER

How do these differences affect cross-species relationships?

If your leads are different species, their magical differences may be a source of wonder, miscommunication, or incompatibility. What assumptions does each character carry about the other's magic?

YOUR ANSWER

Are some species considered magically superior or inferior? How does that hierarchy affect your characters?

ARE SOME SPECIES CONSIDERED MAGICALLY SUPERIOR OR INFERIOR? HOW DOES THAT HIERARCHY AFFECT YOUR CHARACTERS?

Integration Check

How does your magic system connect to the rest of your world?

SYSTEM	HOW MAGIC CONNECTS	EXAMPLE
Geography	Magic tied to locations, ley lines, corrupted lands	<i>ACOTAR</i> : each court has distinct territory and magical nature
Government & Law	Who regulates magic, who's conscripted, who's banned	<i>Serpent & Dove</i> : the Church hunts witches
Religion & Belief	Is magic divine? Heretical? Sacred?	<i>The Priory of the Orange Tree</i> : magic split between faiths
Culture & Custom	Magical traditions, rituals, social status of mages	<i>Gideon the Ninth</i> : necromantic Houses with distinct cultures
Economy & Trade	Magical goods, enchanted items, mage labour	Magical resources as trade goods and political leverage
History	Past magical wars, catastrophes, golden ages	<i>The Fifth Season</i> : civilisation shaped by seismic magic

Map your magic system's connections to the rest of your world:

Your magic doesn't exist in isolation. Use the reference table above for inspiration, then fill in how your magic connects to each element. Skip any that don't apply.

How does your magic system connect to each part of your world?

Use the reference table above. For each system that applies (geography, government, religion, culture, economy, history), write a sentence or two about how magic integrates – and note where that integration puts pressure on your leads.

YOUR ANSWER

Quick Reference

This is your magic system at a glance. Fill it in as you work through the section, or come back to it at the end. If any row is blank, that's fine; it might not apply to your system. If you can't fill in a row that should apply, that's a signal to revisit that part of the section.

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
Magic type(s)	
Source	
Who can use it	
How it's performed	
What it looks/feels like	
Main cost	

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
Biggest limitation	
Environmental hazards	
Protagonist's abilities	
Love Interest's abilities	
Bond/connection (if any)	
Forbidden/dangerous aspects	
How magic connects your leads	

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
How magic divides your leads	
Hard ← or → Soft	

Consistency Check

Write out your magic system in two or three sentences:

This summary should capture the essence: source, who can use it, how it works, main cost, and biggest limit. If you can't summarise it clearly, the system may need simplification.

YOUR ANSWER

Does your magic system contradict itself anywhere?

For example: "Magic is extremely rare" but also "Every noble family has a court mage."

YOUR ANSWER

Think of the biggest problem your protagonist faces.

If a sceptical reader asked “Why didn’t they just use magic to fix that?” what’s your answer?

YOUR ANSWER

What’s one thing you’re still unsure about in your magic system?

Write it down. You may figure it out as you draft, or in later sections.

YOUR ANSWER

Final Thought

The best magic systems aren't about power. They're about cost, consequence, and choice. Every time your character reaches for their magic, they should be weighing what they gain against what they risk.

Magic in romantasy should create as many obstacles as it removes. Every ability comes with a cost, a limitation, a social consequence, or a danger. And the most romantic uses of magic aren't the ones built into the system. They're the ones your characters invent. Private gestures, secret communications, the choice to use power gently when gentleness isn't required.

Whether your magic includes fated bonds or not, the real intimacy comes from characters choosing each other. The bond can say they're matched; only the characters can prove it true.

What problems does magic create for your characters that they couldn't have without it? The answer to that question is where your most interesting conflict lives.



What's Next

You now have a magic system with a source, rules, costs, and limits, and you know how it connects to your romance. Here's where to take it from here:

- **Section 9: Technology & Infrastructure.** How does magic interact with (or replace) technology in daily life? Your magic's capabilities shape what your civilisation needs to build.
- **Section 5: Government, Power & Law.** Magic creates power, and power creates politics. Who regulates magic, who's conscripted, and who's banned will flow directly from the decisions you made here.
- **Section 6: Religion, Myth & Prophecy.** If your magic has a divine source, your religious institutions should reflect it. If magic contradicts faith, that tension drives story.
- **Section 2: Flora, Fauna & Ecosystems.** Magical creatures, corrupted lands, and enchanted resources all need to fit the natural world you're building.
- **Section 13: The Pressure Cooker.** Your magic system's costs and limits are some of the strongest sources of pressure on your characters. Bring them forward when you stress-test your world.